DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

From Judgment to Mercy: The Power of the Shofar

Derech Hashem 4:8:4

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 8, paragraph 4 (with a look back at Part 2, Chapter 8, paragraph 1) **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Thursday 5 May 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Rosh Hashanah: a world remade and judged

Having finished Sukkot, Hanukkah and Purim, the class returned to the paragraph on Rosh Hashanah. On this day God judges the whole universe and renews all existence for a new cycle. As explained last time, each year the world is recreated for another year.

As learned in Part 2, there is a whole system of heavenly courts, with defence and prosecution, and on this day of renewal the prosecutor brings forward the sins of humanity. God commands us to blow the shofar for two purposes:

1. That His conduct with us should be infused with rahamim, mercy, rather than the strictness of din.
2. To confuse the prosecutor, so that he does not prosecute.

Can God overlook sins?

The Ramhal raises a difficulty. As explained in Part 2, just as it is not fitting for a person to receive good without earning it, so it is also part of justice itself that certain deeds should cause God not to be exacting.

The Rabbi explained why this needs saying. The Gemara says that whoever claims God simply overlooks things will have his life overlooked. To say God does not care what I do is an insult. So what is mercy? If I see my son doing wrong and ignore it, how is that different from God ignoring things? A participant suggested that mercy means giving a lighter blow rather than a full one.

The Rabbi pointed to the Gemara he spoke about in a sermon before Rosh Hashanah the previous year. People look for all kinds of segulot for a good year: visiting graves, giving to particular causes. But the Gemara says that whoever is not exacting with others has his own sins passed over. It is measure for measure: as you overlook others, God overlooks you.

The Ramhal's line resolves the problem: it is justice itself that we should be treated with mercy. God cannot simply ignore. But when a person acts in a certain way, judgment itself dictates

that he receive mercy. Two people may commit the same wrong, but the one who is easy-going with others is treated differently.

Why consequences are good for us

The Rabbi explained why God cannot just ignore what we do. Even in our own lives, ignoring the consequences of actions means the actions are not important. Knowing there are consequences, here and not only in the next world, gives meaning to what we do and a framework for how we behave. A participant added that without consequences there would be mayhem. "Even without that coming back to bite us," the Rabbi said, "if what I choose has no consequences, what value is my choice?"

So there are certain things that God has made part of the judgment itself, which move Him away from exacting judgment to mercy. The Ramhal gives two: being willing to forgo the wrongs others do to us, and blowing the shofar.

A participant asked whether this is like a balancing scale, with mercy weighing against sins. The Rabbi said that is a misconception: bad is never simply cancelled because the good outweighs it. Even with a thousand times more good, bad has its consequences; only teshuvah, or mercy, removes it.

How the shofar brings mercy

The Ramhal says the details depend on deep roots, but the intention is to awaken the merit of the forefathers (as with Yishak at the Akedah), to arouse mercy and sweeten judgment, to humble the evil forces, and, the key line, for God to use His supremacy and conduct the world through Yihud Hashem. Teshuvah comes together with it.

The Rabbi explained: God created the world with din, and that is how He normally conducts it. The purpose of the world is that we choose, and by choosing good we reveal His oneness, rejecting everything that seems to deny that He is in control. The shofar is the coronation of Hakadosh Barukh Hu. That is why the prayers of Rosh Hashanah are so universal, focused on the whole world: if His oneness is revealed across the world, everything else falls into place. Recognising Yihud Hashem moves God, as it were, from the chair of judgment to the chair of mercy.

A participant stressed that blowing the shofar is not just music: one must also mean it. The Rabbi agreed; that is why teshuvah comes with it.

The parent and the child

The Rabbi gave an analogy. A child runs into the road and is almost killed. You must respond, not out of anger but so that he learns: that is din. Then the child gives you a smile, his eyes shining, says something that makes you laugh, and you think: I still need to tell him he did wrong, but I just love this child. You make him aware, but you do not punish. The way he interacted with you changed the whole relationship. The same is true of a teacher and a pupil.

"What rahamim means is: I'm going to deal with you not exactingly." That is the key to Rosh Hashanah, and the words we pray: move from the chair of judgment to the chair of mercy. We

get there in two ways: by being merciful with others, and by blowing the shofar and recognising God's unity over all humanity.

This also explains the three parts of Musaf: Zikhronot, remembrance, arousing the merit of the forefathers; Shofarot, the power of the shofar; and Malkhuyot, kingship, declaring that Hashem is One and King of all.

Rules God made, and can set aside

The Rabbi took the group back to Part 2, Chapter 8, paragraph 1, learned about a year earlier. There the Ramhal explains that God conducts the world in two ways: through judgment, sometimes softened, and at times by completely overlooking and acting only with mercy, as He told Moshe. Because He wants human choice, He set up a world of justice and, as it were, subjected His will to the deeds of human beings. But in truth nothing binds Him. When He wishes to use His supremacy and set aside the laws He made, He does so. This is called the conduct of Yihud.

His analogy: a parent sets a rule that a child who wakes up late gets no snack the next day. "I really want to give you that lollipop, but I can't, because I'd be breaking my own rules." But sometimes, out of love, the parent says: I don't mind my rules. Rosh Hashanah is that time, which is why the shofar is the centre of the day and recognising God's unity is so critical. The shofar can bring God to erase the sins entirely: "We're not going to deal with it."

Summary

- On Rosh Hashanah the world is recreated and judged; the shofar brings mercy and silences the prosecutor.
- God cannot simply ignore sin, since consequences give our choices meaning, but justice itself grants mercy to those who are not exacting with others.
- Mercy is not a scale where good outweighs bad; it is God choosing not to be exacting.
- The shofar crowns God and reveals His unity, moving Him from the chair of judgment to the chair of mercy, as in Zikhronot, Shofarot and Malkhuyot.
- God bound Himself to rules of justice for our sake, and on Rosh Hashanah, out of love, He can set them aside.

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